

NATIONAL ENVIRONMENTAL ACTION PLAN

1992-1996

Ministry of Environment and Parliamentary Affairs October 1991

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CONTRIBUTORS

- **Land and Water** — Prof C M Madduma Bandara, Mr K A K Jayatilake, Mr L K Seneviratne, Mr A S Widanapathirana
- **Forestry** — Mr H M Bandaratilake
- **Bio-diversity and Wildlife** — Mr Malcolm A B Jansen
- **Urban Pollution and Industrial Pollution** — Mr P Illangovan, Dr (Ms) L R Sally
- **Energy** — Dr T Siyambalapitiya
- **Coastal Resources** — Ms D Sadacharan
- **Education and Culture** — Mr Sunil Sarath Perera, Mr A K Gunapala
- **Institutional Capacity** — Mr Malcolm F Baldwin, Mr K A K Jayatilake

MANUSCRIPT AND TYPESETTING

Ms Zuhura Pakeer, Ms Mankesh Veliah

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MESSAGE FROM HONOURABLE MINISTER OF ENVIRONMENT AND PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS

We have had many ambitious economic development programmes in the forty three years, since

Independence. Until recently, there has been inadequate attention paid to the environmental aspects. However today, we are firmly committed to the concept of sustainable development and the need to protect and manage the environment. We are fully alert to the consequences of ignoring the environmental impacts of social and economic activities.

The enactment by Parliament of the National Environmental Act of 1980, the establishment of the Central Environmental Authority in 1981 under that Act, and the Environmental Council in 1982, the establishment of District Environmental Agencies in 1984, the Amendment to the National Environmental Act in 1988, the adoption of the National Environmental (Protection and Quality) Regulations of 1990, and above all, the creation in 1990 of a Ministry of Cabinet rank to be in-charge of the subject of environment, are important National landmarks in the progress towards legislative and institutional development in the field of environment.

The National Environmental Action Plan marks another major advance. This five year plan is based on national priorities and on an assessment of resource availability. It is anticipated that the components of the plan will soon be incorporated into the annual work plans of the agencies responsible for the various sectors covered. I have no doubt that the National Environmental Action Plan will set the environmental agenda for the next five years and help to ensure that we are firmly on the path of environmentally sustainable development.

(M VINCENT PERERA) *MINISTER OF ENVIRONMENT AND PARLIAMENTARY AFFAIRS*

MESSAGE FROM HONOURABLE MINISTER OF ENVIRONMENT

It is with great pleasure and sincere dedication that we, the Government of Sri Lanka (GOSL), together with the Ministry of Environment, the Central Environmental Authority (CEA) and all other allied agencies, present this National Environmental Action Plan (NEAP), a document that has been substantially prepared by Sri Lankan resource persons identifying local environmental issues and making efforts for providing solutions to such issues. This Action Plan can well be considered as a graduation of knowledge acquired through extensive studies in the field of environment. In other words, this NEAP contains the core contents of: (a) the Action Plan of the National Conservation Strategy (NCS) prepared by the CEA under the patronage of the Ministry of Environment and with an effective feedback from all who matter in the field of environment, including NGOs; (b) the Environmental Action Plan prepared by the GOSL together with the World Bank; and (c) the Sri Lanka National Report to the United Nations Conference on Environment and Development (UNCED) in 1992 in Brazil.

It should be mentioned that the origin of the NEAP stems from the efforts of the World Commission on Environment and Development which put out its path-breaking Report, *OUR COMMON FUTURE* (1987). Consequent upon the publication of this Report, the International Union for Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources (IUCN) went ahead with the responsibility of alerting Governments to the urgent need for environmental conservation and development, particularly through its document titled *The World Conservation Strategy*. The GOSL has been among the first to recognize the objectives laid down by the IUCN, and on a proposal made by His Excellency Ranasinghe Premadasa as the then Prime Minister, the former President of Sri Lanka appointed, in 1982, a Task Force for the preparation of a NCS for Sri Lanka.

In consequence, Sri Lanka's NCS which came out as a blue print in December 1988 was accepted by the Government as the declaration of National Policy in relation to the conservation of nature and natural resources in the country. The next step needed in the process was the transformation of this Strategy from a general statement of programmes and principles to a set of policy guidelines and action-oriented plan. Through a mechanism of steering committees and working groups, a draft Action Plan of the NCS was developed by the CEA, after discussion with the Ministry of Environment, the Environmental Council, the NGOs and the Secretaries of the allied Ministries. In the meantime, with the assistance of the Government of Sri Lanka, the staff of the World Bank initiated preparing an Environmental Action Plan, known as EAP, embodying major recommendations of the draft Action Plan of the NCS and concentrating on a few major environmental issues. Then a policy decision was taken for the preparation of one single Action Plan embodying not only the core contents and recommendations of the Action Plan of the NCS and EAP but also those of the country's National Report prepared for the UNCED to be held in Brazil in July 1992. The final outcome of all these efforts is the present NEAP for which a foreword is written by me as Minister of Environment. I have no doubt that this Action Plan will serve as an important guidebook for introducing environmental aspects to the country's development process which has now successfully entered into a take-off stage.

(DR WIMAL WICKRAMASINGHE) *MINISTER OF ENVIRONMENT AND MINISTER OF STATE FOR POLICY PLANNING AND IMPLEMENTATION*